

International Baccalaureate

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HL English A Language & Literature essay

Text(s) Written On: Othello

Question: How, and to what effect, does Shakespeare portray female obedience and resistance to patriarchal authority in Othello?

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It is a social expectation, in patriarchal societies, that females must obey their superior, men. Ephesians 5:22 says, “Wives, submit yourselves to your own husbands as you do to the Lord” (New International Version), a verse deeply rooted in this social expectation, written long before Shakespeare’s Othello. As societies modernise, there comes resistance attempts to such gender inequalities, yet such traditions often remain powerful. In the tragic play Othello, Shakespeare portrays various male-female relationships and interactions, characterized by different power-dynamics, yet all bound by cultural and social expectations. Through these relationships, Shakespeare presents patriarchy as socially expecting female obedience, even framed as affection and religion, and in doing so, he invites the audience to critically reflect on how such a system silences women and leads to tragedies.

Through the use of metaphor, repetition and diction, Shakespeare underscores the social expectations of women in a patriarchal society. Female characters are objectified and expected to obey male authorities in relationships, contextualizing efforts of female resistance and obedience for the audience. The objectification of women is especially represented in the scene where Iago, Desdemona and Emilia are talking and waiting for Othello’s arrival in Cyprus. Iago, a subordinate flag bearer of lower social status, speaks with authority to Desdemona and Emilia. He uses a series of metaphors to describe women’s social functions as superficial. He compares them to decorative “pictures”, animalistic “wildcats”, and even “devils” – a biblical allusion (Shakespeare 2.1.108-111). Shakespeare uses this degrading language to underscore the association of women with being decorative and morally flawed. The tension is further heightened through Iago’s repetition of “Come on, come on” (2.1.108). He intends to pressure Desdemona to agree with his degrading claims, reinforcing the power-imbalance between

gender. Shakespeare uses this repetition to not only underscore Iago's mocking and dismissive tone, but also to highlight how such ideas are normalized within society, as it happens in a public conversation. Shakespeare guides the audience to feel discomfort towards the casual confidence at which Iago talks. Earlier in the play, when Brabantio confronts Desdemona about whether she has married Othello, he refers to "where most [she owes] obedience", framing her choice as duty (1.3.179). Desdemona replies that she shares a "divided duty" between her father and her husband (1.3.181). Through the emphasis on "obedience" and "duty", Shakespeare underscores the presence of a hierarchy, and a sense of power-transfer from father to husband within a family (1.3.179-181). Together, Shakespeare demonstrates for the audience how female characters in a patriarchal society are consistently objectified and expected to obey male authority.

While patriarchal beliefs are normalized, Shakespeare also presents moments of resistance attempts. Through the use of sensory metaphor and chiasmus, Shakespeare highlights how voices challenging the patriarchy are being silenced. Shakespeare underscores the attempt of female characters to call for gender equality by using sensory metaphor. Emilia, in her conversation with Desdemona about Othello's abnormal aggressive actions, compares the senses between wives and husbands to emphasize her view on equality within marriage. She claims that wives "see and smell" as husbands do, and "have palates both for sweet and sour" as husbands do (4.3.94-97). Through the metaphor, Shakespeare highlights how women have the same capacities as men do, challenging the justice of male authorities. However, this private between two women had limited impact, nobody is directly confronted. Moreover, Emilia's public resistance later leads immediately to her death, further highlighting how resistances to patriarchal beliefs will lead to destructive consequences. The tragedy of her awareness of injustice juxtaposed with her death

invites the audience to feel pity for her, hence coming to realize the danger and confinement of women. Shakespeare further strengthens the critique through Emilia's claims of "the ills we do, [husbands] ills instruct us so" (4.3.103). Shakespeare uses this chiasmus between female actions and male instructions to shift the responsibility from women to men. This suggests how, due to the extreme imbalance of power, female wrongdoings are caused by male aggressive actions. The inclusive pronouns "we" and "us" frame the situation as a shared experience by women. In doing so, Shakespeare invites the audience to sympathize with the female victims' perspective, criticizing the effects of extreme power-imbalance within marriage in a patriarchy. Yet Shakespeare lets Emilia's words of wisdom appear only shortly before her tragic death, reinforcing the limitation of female voices and resistances within a male-dominated society.

Alongside limited resistance attempts, obedience is more frequently found. Shakespeare highlights how obedience is achieved through characters internalizing patriarchal beliefs and values, through the use of contradiction and repetition. After Othello is convinced of Desdemona's infidelity and instructs her to wait for him, she speaks with Emilia about Othello's accusations and abusive behaviour. Compared to Emilia's critique towards Othello's disrespectful and unjust actions, Desdemona rationalizes them and reframes "[Othello's] stubbornness, [...] checks [and] frowns" as his signs of "grace and favor" in the marriage (4.3.20-21). Othello's "stubbornness" implies his inflexibility, his "checks" suggest control, while his "frowns" reflect his emotional instability. Yet Desdemona interprets these as expressions of love. Shakespeare uses the contradiction between the harsh imagery and Desdemona's embracing attitude towards them to reveal how obedience leads to the internalization of such beliefs. The audience is invited to feel discomfort at her attempt to justify Othello's actions, and

to critically view the distorted view on violence that she has adapted in the patriarchal environment. Desdemona's obedience is further demonstrated in her repeated statement that "[her] love [...] approve[s] him" (4.3.18-19). This suggests that she is actively persuading herself of the legitimacy of Othello's abusive actions, taking over the responsibility. Shakespeare highlights the irony in Othello's ruthless violence and Desdemona's extreme form of obedience. Despite such obedience, Desdemona is tragically murdered by Othello. Through this contradiction and irony, Shakespeare invites the reader to not only pity Desdemona, but also to view her as the tragic victim of patriarchal teachings. Moreover, Shakespeare also highlights how the experience of familial abuse and female obedience is universal. As Emilia and Desdemona continue talking, Desdemona starts singing the song "Willow", again claiming how "[Othello's] scorn [she] approve[s]" (4.3.51). By letting the same message echo again in this song, Shakespeare underscored this being a shared experience of many females in the past. Shakespeare uses contradiction and repetition to underscore obedience in the form of rationalising abusive actions performed by male authorities in a male-dominance society. Shakespeare guides the audience to realize how patriarchal values distort female perception and to reflect upon the power associated with love, and how this is a universal experience.

Shakespeare further heightens the extent of obedience of characters by framing male powers in the patriarchy with religious association. On the night of Desdemona's death, Othello demands Desdemona to confess any "crime" or "sins" to heaven before he kills her (5.2.26-39). Othello views himself as having the divine duty to perform justice in the name of God. Desdemona, despite knowing her innocence, requests "heaven", Othello, for "mercy on [her]" (5.2.33). Through the use of a religious diction, Shakespeare investigates how female obedience can be

achieved through the establishment of male figures as divine authority. The metaphor of Othello as “heaven” characterizes the extent of power and control he possesses over Desdemona, so that Desdemona’s obedience to him is as natural as religious confinements. Thus, Shakespeare portrays obedience as absolute and extending beyond social implications into spiritual control. Desdemona’s obedience is further reinforced through characterizing Othello into the role of a teacher who “do teach young babes”, and herself being the “child to chiding” (4.2.112-114). Through this metaphor of presenting herself as a vulnerable and ignorant child, she diminishes herself to legitimate Othello’s action. She articulates how she is simply unused to such treatments and that Othello has done nothing wrong. Through Desdemona’s action of putting Othello at higher status and moral grounds, she excuses Othello from being responsible for her suffering. Shakespeare invites the audience to observe this heightened scene critically, and to recognise how Desdemona’s distorted view has been shaped by the patriarchy. Ultimately, Desdemona recognizes the source for her suffering as “[her] wretched fortune”, connoting the inevitable nature of tragedy (4.2.123). However, the audience knows that her suffering actually stems from Iago’s manipulation and Othello’s jealousy, both human-caused. Shakespeare uses this dramatic irony to encourage the audience to reflect upon the mental confinement arising from a patriarchy and the devastating consequences of blind obedience.

Overall, Shakespeare portrays female obedience as socially normalised, and psychologically internalized, while resistances remain limited or completely silenced. Obedience is achieved through framing abusive behaviors as signs of love or being divine. He comments and reminds the audience of the tragic nature of this play and highlights how the patriarchal system plays a critical role in contributing to the death of multiple characters. Through this, Shakespeare

encourages the audience to reflect upon concepts such as justice and power-dynamics between genders.

Works Cited

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